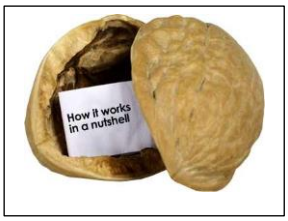
Title London by William Blake

The poem in a nutshell….



- Very negative in tone. Reflects Blake's disillusionment with state.
- A walk through London reveals it to be a place where freedom is restricted and poverty is rife.
- Institutions such as the Church and the monarchy are riddled with hypocrisy as money is spent on their upkeep rather than improving the life chances of the poor.

Context

- *London* was published in 1793, four years after the outbreak of the French Revolution. Is Blake calling for the poor people of London to rise up and seize power?
- London was becoming more and more industrial. Blake expresses his concerns on impact for city and its people.

3 Key Quotes

Quote	Method	What effect is created?
"And mark in every face I meet/ Marks of weakness, marks of woe."	Repetition of 'mark', emphasises physical misery that London inhabitants display	Reader is forced to acknowledge inescapability of physical damage caused by London. We too feel imprisoned by repetition?
"The mind-forg'd manacles I hear."	Metaphor	Sympathy from the reader as the restrictions on freedom are caused by the mind.
"And blights with plagues the marriage hearse"	Juxtaposition	Striking for reader as two images, 'marriage' and 'hearse', aren't normally associated are placed together. London is a city of duplicity and a difficult environment in which to sustain happiness. An attack on the Church and the hypocrisy of this institution?

Aspects of Power or Conflict

Power of state – individuals are powerless to restrictions imposed from above 'chartered streets'

Political **conflict** – Church and King are reinforcing the inequality of society. Poor are victims.

Potential **power** of people – if they were to rise up in revolution.

Poems that can be linked

Storm on the Island

PEAL Table: Cluster 4, *Storm on the Island* and *London*

	Point (AO1)	Evidence (AO1)	Analysis (AO2)	Link (AO3)
Storm on the Island	The poet has used imagery and effective language in Storm on the Island.	"We are bombarded by the empty air"	Attacked by a threat that cannot be seen. Reinforces unpredictability of attacks and powerlessness to defend against the elements. Creates the image of combat. Powerful, violent verb 'bombard'	The poets have used different techniques to achieve ideas about a lack of power.
London	The poet has used repetition in London.	"And mark in every face I meet/ Marks of weakness, marks of woe."	Reader is forced to acknowledge inescapability of physical damage caused by London. Repetition of 'mark', emphasises physical misery that London inhabitants display We too feel imprisoned by repetition?	
Storm on the Island	The author has used contrast in the form of an oxymoron	The sea is described as 'exploding comfortably'	Striking and unusual description for reader as it seems contradictory. Suggests this is something that it has done before and will do again. Appeals to senses as this is something we can visualise and imagine the sound of.	Both poets have used strong contrasts to create ideas about power.
London	On the other hand, the author of London has used contrast in the form of juxtaposition	"And blights with plagues the marriage hearse"	Striking for reader as two images, 'marriage' and 'hearse', aren't normally associated are placed together. London is a city of duplicity and a difficult environment in which to sustain happiness. An attack on the Church and the hypocrisy of this institution?	
Storm on the Island	The poet has created imagery through the use of a simile	"the flung spray hits/The very windows, spits like a tame cat/ Turned savage"	Sea is uncontrollable, unpredictable. Wild like a cat.	Both poets have created imagery to allow the reader to picture and feel the struggles each subject has with power.
London	Whereas the author of London has created imagery through the use of a metaphor	"The mind-forg'd manacles I hear."	Sympathy from the reader as the restrictions on freedom are caused by the mind.	